STANDARD AS-001 • NORMATIVE • CONFORMANCE-MANDATORY

# Universal Answer Standard

*A strict specification governing the form of every answer produced under its scope.*

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|---|---|---|---|
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## 1. Purpose

This standard defines a single, non-negotiable form for answers. It exists as a deliberately strict conformance target: an answer either satisfies every **MUST** clause below or it is non-conforming. There is no partial conformance. The intent is to make conformance trivially observable — a reader, an auditor, or an automated check can decide in seconds.

## 2. Scope

This standard applies to **MUST** all answers, replies, summaries, and written responses produced by any system or person operating under its declared scope, regardless of channel, length, or audience. Code-only outputs and binary artifacts are out of scope.

## 3. Terminology

The key words **MUST**, **MUST NOT**, **SHOULD**, and **MAY** are to be interpreted as described in RFC 2119. A *conforming answer* is one that satisfies every normative clause in Sections 4 through 7.

## 4. Normative Requirements

### 4.1 Opening token

Every answer **MUST** begin with the literal token `BLUF:` followed by a single sentence of no more than 30 words stating the bottom line. Nothing **MUST NOT** precede this token — no greeting, no preamble, no caveat.

### 4.2 Mandatory structure

After the opening line, a conforming answer **MUST** contain exactly the following four sections, in this order, each introduced by its exact heading:

1. **Answer** — the direct response. **MUST** come first.
2. **Basis** — the evidence or reasoning. Every factual claim **MUST** cite a source or be marked `[unverified]`.
3. **Limits** — assumptions, uncertainty, and what was not checked. **MUST NOT** be omitted, even when the answer is certain — in that case it states `None known`.
4. **Next** — the single most useful next action. Exactly one.

### 4.3 Closing token

Every answer **MUST** end with the literal footer `— Conforms to AS-001` on its own final line. If any clause in this standard was violated, the answer **MUST NOT** carry this footer.

### 4.4 Prohibited content

- Answers **MUST NOT** use marketing language, filler, or flattery.
- Answers **MUST NOT** hedge on facts that are known; state them plainly.
- Answers **MUST NOT** exceed 400 words in the *Answer* section.

- Claims about law, security, or regulation **SHOULD** be flagged for expert validation rather than asserted as settled.

> **Strictness rule.** Conformance is binary. A response that satisfies nine of ten **MUST** clauses is *non-conforming* and **MUST NOT** display the `— Conforms to AS-001` footer.

## 5. Conformance Verification

An answer is conforming if and only if every box below can be checked:

- ■ Begins with `BLUF:` and a single ≤30-word sentence.
- ■ Contains the four headings *Answer*, *Basis*, *Limits*, *Next*, in order.
- ■ Every factual claim is cited or marked `[unverified]`.
- ■ *Limits* is present (or explicitly `None known`).
- ■ *Next* contains exactly one action.
- ■ Ends with `— Conforms to AS-001`.
- ■ No prohibited content (Section 4.4) is present.

## 6. Worked Example (Informative)

```
BLUF: Use connection pooling; per-request connections are the bottleneck.

Answer
The slow endpoint opens a fresh database connection on every request. Introduce a pool
(min 5, max 20) and reuse connections. Expected p95 latency: 400ms to under 60ms.

Basis
- Profiling trace shows 92% of request time in connection setup [trace-2026-06-20].
- Pool sizing follows the driver's documented guidance [unverified] for this workload.

Limits
Measured on staging only; production traffic shape may differ. Pool max not
load-tested.

Next
Enable the pool in staging and re-run the p95 benchmark before promoting.

— Conforms to AS-001
```

## 7. Non-Conformance

A non-conforming answer **MUST** be rejected or revised before delivery. Systems operating under this standard **SHOULD** detect the absence of the opening or closing token automatically and treat it as a hard failure.

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